

What makes NFC more secure?

First, NFC transactions are low-value payment transactions. So it is a security risk that the banks are willing to take for the sake of convenience. For example, today, you cannot make a 10,000-rupees NFC payment. You would only be able to pay for tokens, parking and similar small things.

Second, there have been several pilot schemes and trials from which a lot has been learnt. So the technology is now more mature and secure.

It is important to recognise that nothing is 100 per cent secure, 100 per cent of the time, and security provision should always aim to be one step ahead of the hackers. Even when a technology such as NFC is deployed, it is important that security measures continue to be assessed and security elements are added wherever necessary to protect customers. To achieve this, during the R&D stage technology developers should engage with testing and evaluation consultancies such as FIME. This will ensure from the start that solutions align to the latest requirements, saving significant time and money.

Do you consider NFC to be a disruptive technology?

I personally believe that NFC will not replace cards completely just yet. India consists of more cash-happy people and we are only just getting comfortable with cards. It

is important to first establish NFC as a secure technology before it is adopted by consumers in India.

Contact cards will continue to exist in India for a while alongside newer technologies such as NFC and contactless cards.

What is the technical challenge in testing NFC technology?

One challenge faced is handset reception. The antenna on an NFC-enabled handset can impact the NFC connection. This is a challenge for handset developers as the antenna on a conventional reader is different from that on a mobile device.

Given the size of the handset and the communication that takes place between the phone and its mobile network, specific radio frequency (RF) experience is required to implement NFC capabilities within a handset. This is a challenge for mobile handset manufacturers, who are often newcomers to the contactless market and need to design specific RF antennae for NFC mobile devices.

There has been a case where we had to tell the handset manufacturer that their antenna was positioned the wrong way. The only way to overcome challenges like this is rigorous testing of handsets from the beginning and throughout the development process. ●

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